

If You're Single

If you're not married but have children or dependent relatives living with you, you may be able to file as a **head of household**. This status generally allows you to pay less tax than an ordinary single person. To see if you qualify, check the instruction booklet that comes with your tax forms, or go to www.irs.gov and consult Publication 501, *Exemptions, Standard Deduction, and Filing Information*.

↓ MAXIMIZING YOUR TAX BREAKS

Although the government wants citizens to pay their fair share of taxes, it does offer taxpayers ways to reduce the amount of their income that's subject to tax. This section will discuss the various tax breaks for which you may be eligible.

IF YOU CHANGE YOUR NAME, TELL SOCIAL SECURITY

If you get married (or divorced) and change your last name, contact the Social Security Administration. The IRS checks in with Social Security to make sure that the name you use matches for both. If you change your name without alerting the Social Security Administration, the IRS may delay sending you the refund check you are due. What's more, you might not get credit for the money your employer deducts from your paycheck and sends to Social Security. Go to www.ssa.gov or call 800-772-1213 to get a copy of Form SS-5, which you'll have to fill out to register your new name.

Exemptions and Deductions

One type of tax break available to most taxpayers is an **exemption**, a specific amount (\$3,650 in 2009) that can be subtracted from your taxable income. If you're single and have no children (and are not being claimed as